



Dr Alok Nath De practising for fitness

from both the companies. “The same postman brought the two offer letters on the same day. I found the phrase so true: God helps those who help themselves. The power of hope and ambition beats everything,” he remembers.

He went with one of these companies—Hughes Software Systems in Gurgaon. His interview with the Director of Hughes India had happened while he was still in Canada. Incidentally, the Director had made it a point to highlight how different his life would be once Alok Nath was back in India.

In such a case, one might take a moment to reconsider the decision. But Alok Nath knew exactly what he wanted. “I told the executive that I am cognizant of all of that, and I was making the decision while being fully aware. I am ready to face challenges as they come.”

This director who also became his manager and is now a good friend, was a source of inspiration for Alok Nath as he made his switch so seamless; he never felt like he had left home. At Hughes too, Alok Nath’s vision for joining a company did not alter—he wanted to do something that nobody else was doing or was willing to do.

He recalls, “During that time, digital signal processing in the base layer was effectively not there in Hughes communication stack. Many prospective clients said that they

could have a service agreement with Hughes if that solution could be included in service delivery. That was truly a defining statement for me.”

He was entrusted with building a team for the same. Here came a moment to take something from zero to one, an opportunity of intrapreneurship. “Taking something from level one and scaling it to infinity is relatively easy because you have done it once. Building something from zero to one is the real challenge.”

Alok Nath had to build a team of twenty people with strong DSP expertise and also start securing the DSP business beyond Hughes. It gave him joy that, due to this twenty-member team, Hughes could garner indirectly about eighty other people in higher-level stack areas. And this continued scaling up.

After a four-year stint at Hughes, he had a new itch. Even though the chip was never his core, he realised that semiconductors and VLSI design were a part of telecommunications and had a tremendous potential. So, he decided to join ST-Microelectronics, which was looking to start telecom business *ab initio* in 2003. He joined them as the head of this division.

In 2008, when a joint venture between STMicroelectronics and Ericsson was signed, Alok Nath was appointed as the MD of the group in India. He was handling the teams of both Noida and Bengaluru. He built

an enviable team by internal transfer, external hiring as well as company acquisitions. By the time he left, he had 1000 team members.

To understand the full stack better, he became a ‘student’ of chip design. Even though he was the MD, he would often join the freshers during their training sessions to learn more about frontend and backend chip design, the processes and nuances. “In order to make decisions as an MD and interact as a global leader, I needed to know the subject to a great extent. I thought it was an integral part of decision making and I had to learn it to do my job well.”

After eight good years at ST-Ericsson, a world giant was waiting for Alok Nath to knock on their door.

Samsung and a missed opportunity

Alok Nath had the good taste of administrative life for a long time at ST-Ericsson where he was also a Board Director of the company, and he now craved for a more technical role. He wanted to lead with technology. But before that, he wanted to pause and take time to contemplate—much like he used to do in his childhood days.

He took a sabbatical of about six months and decided to experiment with a few things during the period. He taught at IIT Delhi as an Adjunct Professor, served as a consultant to Accenture, and mentored a location-technology based startup during this phase. While mentoring the startup, he got down to interacting with the ground-level customers to understand things from their perspective. “If you can take a month or even a few days to interact with the people on the ground, there is no better learning than this. I would not trade this for anything else.”

But as they say, you cannot hide exceptional talent anywhere. This time, Alok Nath’s talent was found by South Korean electronics giant Sam-